mind. It was only when I landed at the airbase that I realized the magnitude of this war. The airbase was a madhouse, with all kinds of aircraft landing and taking off at short intervals. The crew was running haphazard on the airfield and security was increased almost ten times of the usual. Even the two rooms of our detachment were full of aircrew and our parking space was no longer reserved. I somehow managed a room for myself and stayed there for the next three days, without flying any sorties. The flying was not planned and was subject to requirement. The morning briefings were scheduled every day before sunrise, and I would attend them. A threat could be felt in the air. A war-like situation had come upon us. In the midst of this chaos, the fighter pilots and all the other male pilots had started to realize that a woman officer was in attendance among them. For many, it was strange, and nobody thought that I would be told to go further into the combat zone. To be honest, I hadn't thought of it either. In one of the briefings, I befriended Flight Lieutenant Banerjee, who was quite jovial, unlike the others, who were still hesitant. He was an ace fighter pilot who also helped me understand what had been going on in Kargil in the last few days.

When the chief operations officer (COO) of Srinagar airbase came to know about my presence there, he was not sure whether women pilot officers should be sent to the combat zone. No written policy existed at the time about women officers' role in active combat. Even then, my unit's detachment commander started planning sorties for me. My first sortie to Kargil was a reconnaissance (recce) sortie. It required flying from the Srinagar airbase and landing at the small airstrip at Kargil before going further for the recce mission. We were required to land at the Kargil airbase to be briefed by the Indian Army, based on their ground intelligence. Indian Army troops knew the ground situation better and it kept changing on an hourly basis, so a detailed briefing had become necessary. We went for the reports in a briefing room at Kargil airstrip, where we were told about the enemy's disposition, heights where our aircraft would be in direct line of the enemy's sight and, therefore, vulnerable to enemy fire and terrain, which could favour us by providing natural cover. I flew a recce sortie